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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: KABIN ADHIKARI/TRN

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' and Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha attend to celebrate the 23rd Armed Police Force (APF) Day in the capital on Tuesday.

Next year's budget will make new departure: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that next year's budget will make a new departure from the past approach, with a strong focus on completing existing projects rather than initiating new ones.

Acknowledging that traditional policies and programmes have proven insufficient to address current challenges, the Prime Minister stressed the importance of prioritizing the conclusion of incomplete projects.

Speaking at a meeting held to discuss the policy, programme and budget of the upcoming fiscal year at Singha Durbar on Tuesday Prime Minister Prachanda expressed concern over the stagnation of completed schemes, cautioning against the addition of new projects that may not be effectively implemented, resulting in the wastage of significant resources.

He urged the Ministry of Finance and the National Planning Commission to take this matter seriously.

Highlighting the need for strategic development planning, Prime Minister Prachanda emphasized that projects should undergo feasibility studies and demonstrate utility. He criticized the practice of allocating budgets without ensuring resources and feasibility, leading to frozen funds. He declared that this year's budget would not follow a scattergun approach but instead strive to complete previously selected plans.

"The signs of economic improvement are promising, but our economy is not without challenges," said Prachanda. He called for a departure from traditional thinking and patterns, emphasizing the importance of selecting plans that contribute to the country's prosperity, even if it means not pleasing everyone. He emphasized the need for a breakthrough in this approach.

» SEE PAGE 6

PEOPLE-ORIENTED POLICY ASSURED

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has pledged to make next fiscal year's policy and programmes and budget people-oriented.

Talking to a delegation from the CPN (UML) party on Tuesday, PM Prachanda said that he was working to transform the structure, time and process of presenting the policy and programmes and the budget and said that he expected his steps to yield positive results.

The delegation, led by UML Chairman and former Prime Minister KP Sharma Oli, presented a memorandum consisting of the demands it collected from the public during its 'resolution journey.'

The UML's journey began from Jhulaghat on November 30 and ended at Chiwabhanjyang on December 17 last year.

Receiving the memorandum, PM Prachanda said that attention drawn by UML on matters of development, public service and prosperity would prove valuable for formulating the policies and budget. He also said that the party's resolution journey had helped strengthen the country's federal democratic republican system. He also promised to address as many issues raised by the main opposition party as possible.

On the occasion, Oli said that the party's journey had helped them understand the realities of the mid-hill region, including status of development works, public psychology, political cooperation and potential for prosperity.

EXPEDITE WORKS OF BUDHIGANDAKI HYDEL: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has asked stakeholders to expedite work on the reservoir-based Budhigandaki Hydropower Project.

Discussing the project with officials of the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation, including Minister Shakti Bahadur Basnet, officials of the Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) and representatives of the Budhigandaki Hydropower Limited (BHL), PM Prachanda reminded everyone that Budhigandaki was not an ordinary project.

"This is a national pride project and a project of multidimensional importance," he stated. "We aim to export 10,000 megawatts of electricity in 10 years. So, this project needs to move forward without delay," he said.

Noting that the necessary land had been acquired and compensation had also been distributed, the PM instructed the Energy Ministry, NEA and BHL to carry out their tasks efficiently.

He said, "Rs. 43 billion has already been distributed in compensation. More land has been frozen for acquisition. A field office has been established and inaugurated. So it will not be right to still think that project may not progress."

He emphasised, "The project must move forward. Please work fast."

"This project will deliver results on multiple fronts," he said.

» SEE PAGE 6

Bagmati Corridor monuments restored to their original state

BY INDIRA ARYAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

To enhance the beauty of the Bagmati River, 28 monuments along the river corridor were reconstructed, spanning from Teku Dovan to Thapathali.

The monuments, which were damaged during the 2015 earthquake, have been reconstructed to restore a traditional appearance along the corridor. This initiative comes at a crucial time when various structures, including ghats, sattals, temples, shrines, and other related structures, have faced deterioration and disappearance.

The initiative was launched by the Bagmati River Basin Improvement Project-Additional Financing (BRBIP-AF) on 6 February 2020, with financial support from the Asian Development Bank. The project's objective is to restore the monuments that were originally constructed during the era of Janga Bahadur Rana.

One important component of the BRBIP is to enhance the health of the river and improve flood management within the Bagmati River Basin. This effort is in line with the vision outlined in the Bagmati Action Plan, which envisions a "Clean, green, and healthy Bagmati River that is full of life and valued by all," said Udhav Nepal, Deputy Project Director, BRBIP-AF.

Indeed, there are several notable ghats along the corridor, each contributing to the cultural and historical richness of the area. These include Teku-Dovan Ghat, Munshi Ghat, Panchanari Ghat, Pachali Ghat, Hanuman Ghat, Kali Ghat, Kaji Ghat, Puret Ghat, Juddha Ghat, Chandra Ghat, and Kal Mochan Ghat.



PHOTO: TRN

Teen Dewal Temple then and now.

Prabha Pokhrel, Team Leader of River Environment Improvement through Community Leadership Development/BRBIP, said that these monuments, constructed over a century ago, carry substantial cultural and historical significance. They were built for purposes such as cremation, and rest, and some even served as lodgings during a time when there were no easy places to stay in the city.

The initiative was undertaken to impart a clean and traditional aesthetics along the corridor. A total of 28 monuments were constructed under three contracts along the Bagmati River corridor, spanning from Thapathali Bridge to the Bishnumati confluence, Pokhrel said.

Under the first contract, 11 monuments were restored for Rs. 375 million, and the project was completed in December 2021. In the second phase, the restoration of 13 monuments was finalized in September 2022, utilising Rs. 471 million.

» SEE PAGE 6

Govt recommends for parliament session on Feb. 5

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

» CABINET DECISIONS

The government has decided to recommend President Ramchandra Paudel to summon the winter session of both the House of Representatives and the National Assembly for 4:00 pm on February 5.

A meeting of the Council of Ministers held on Tuesday recommended the President to summon the House session for February 5, Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma said after the Cabinet meeting.

Earlier, the budget session of the Parliament concluded on November 2, 2023.

Similarly, the Cabinet meeting decided to form a dialogue team to negotiate with the Japanese government officials to finalise the draft agreement on receiving concessional loan assistance worth Rs. 31 billion to implement the Koteshwor Intersection Improvement Project.

Likewise, the government nominated Dr. Asim Bhandari to the post of Coordinator of the National Anti-Doping Agency National Sports Council under Rule 16 of the National Sports Development Regulations-2023.

Construction work of Siddhababa tunnel begins

BY REKHIRAM RANA
Tansen, Jan. 23

Almost 22 months after the signing of the project, construction of the 1.126 km long Siddhababa tunnel way connecting Butwal and Palpa has begun.

The tunnel that falls along the Siddhartha Highway is one of the national pride projects of the government.

The tunnel-digging work began from the south gate after the completion of all essential works required for the tunnel project.

According to the construction company, China State Construction Engineering Corporation Limited, the main tunnel-digging work began after the completion of essential infrastructure tasks including soil testing, setting up a site office, expanding electricity facilities and constructing alternative roads.

The Government signed an agreement with the construction company on March 9, 2022, to complete the project within five years.



The Siddhababa Tunnel Road Project Office in Butwal said that the construction pace would be accelerated once the main work on the tunnel road begins.

Rampukar Jaisawal, the project head, said that after completing all the necessary preparations outside the company, the primary focus is on tunnel digging.

He mentioned that 10.2 per cent of the work on the tunnel route has been completed to date, and the construction company has received corresponding payments.

» SEE PAGE 6

KMC bans vehicle parking in New Road area

BY SUSHMA MAHARJAN
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

Anyone walking down the streets in the New Road area of Kathmandu on Tuesday must have had an entirely different experience. New Road, the business hub of the capital city, didn't look its usual self as the roads seemed significantly wider, with no two- and four-wheelers parked around. Thanks to the proactive measures taken by the Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) in prohibiting vehicles from parking on the blacktopped roads of the city area.

Rohina Suwal, 28, a resident of Khichapokhari, said, "For the first time in my life I have witnessed the New Road area free of traffic on a working day. I am thrilled that I will no longer be stuck in traffic right in front of my own house."

She said being one of the busiest streets in the metropolis, New Road sees a high inflow of businesses and countless people and vehicles. However, the KMC's initiative sets an example that with proper implementation of rules and regulations, the city's hustle and bustle can be managed making it more pedestrian- friendly, she added. She said that after the removal of lined-up vehicles on the sidewalks, it felt like the area did not need road expansion but rather required proper management.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

New Road wears a new look on Tuesday as KMC banned vehicle parking in the area.

Meanwhile, Srijana Basnet of Minbhawan who had arrived in New Road for shopping was a bit surprised to discover the news upon arrival. Confused about where to park her scooter, she also expressed concern about carrying her purchased goods on her own for an extended period. She said, "I like to shop in the area as everything is available at one place. Since there is no parking facility in the area, now I have to schedule my shopping lists."

Chief of KMC Police Raju Nath Pandey said that the KMC had banned vehicles parking in the area to ease the movement of people and lessen crowd at the area. He said, "Since Tuesday morning, vehicles are prohibited to park on the blacktopped roads at New Road Gate, Dharmapath, Pako, Mahabauddha, Bishal Bazzar, Pyukha and Jho Chhen areas."

He said that earlier, the KMC had a contract with various parking organisations for the parking management in the area. As the contract ended on Monday, the KMC imposed a new rule from Tuesday. He said after imposing rules the city police and city vehicles had been patrolling the area for an effective implementation of the rule.

» SEE PAGE 6

National action plan on business and human rights launched

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

The Ministry of Labour, Employment and Social Security (MoLESS) has launched the National Action Plan on Business and Human Rights (NAP-BHR), which is termed a significant milestone in promoting responsible business and strengthening human rights standards in Nepal.

Sharat Singh Bhandari, Minister of the Labour, launched the National Action Plan (NAP) at a programme organised by the Ministry and United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) which provided technical support for the formulation of the action plan.

The NAP-BHR was initially endorsed by the government on 27 December 2023. "It is a clear commitment from the Government of Nepal to promote economic development while safeguarding the rights of its citizens and the environment," said the Minister.

"The private sector affects the daily lives of every individual in Nepal. For this reason, it is important to ensure that businesses respect human rights throughout their operations," he added.

The NAP was developed in alignment with national provisions and commitments to human rights, as well as international human rights standards like the UN Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights (UNGPs) – the most authoritative and widely adopted set of principles for responsible business, unanimously endorsed by the UN Human Rights Council in 2011.



Photo: Kabita Thapa/TRN
Labor Employment and Social Security Minister Sharat Singh Bhandari with Officials in Kathmandu on Tuesday.

It outlines expectations and duties of the government and businesses in Nepal to respect, protect, and fulfil human rights through a comprehensive set of actions across six thematic areas – labour rights, migrant workers' rights, consumer protection, environment and indigenous people's rights, women and children's rights, and non-discrimination, gender and social inclusion.

During the launch event, there was a unified call for collaboration and coordination for the successful implementation of the NAP.

"This milestone presents a clear opportunity for diverse stakeholders to come together to enhance responsible business through a collaborative process over the next five years," said Ayshanie Labé, UNDP Resident Representative for Nepal. "UNDP remains committed to supporting the Government of Nepal in implementing the National Action Plan," she said.

The National Action Plan aims to support companies in managing human rights risks within their operations and supply chains, ensuring they are prepared for an accelerating global shift towards responsible business conduct.

Increasingly, leading global economies are taking action to promote responsible supply chains, for example, through the Government of Japan's Guidelines on Respecting Human Rights in Responsible Supply Chains or the European Union's Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence Directive. The adoption of the National Action Plan by the Government of Nepal sends a strong narrative to investors that Nepal is a good place to do business.

The National Action Plan is the outcome of collaboration between MoLESS, UNDP in Nepal, and other partners, supported by the Government of Japan and the Government of Norway.

This collaborative effort adopted a rigorous, participatory approach, including a series of consultation workshops, focus group discussions, and technical working group discussions to solicit feedback from businesses, civil society organizations (CSOs), international experts, and others on drafts of the action plan to ensure its quality and effectiveness, said the MoLESS.

AIR PASSENGERS TO POKHARA INCREASE

BY SANTOSH SUBEDI
Kaski, Jan. 23

The Pokhara-Mugling Highway has been witnessing frequent disturbances of late due to expansion and maintenance works. This seems to have pushed many people travelling to and from Pokhara to fly.

As per the data maintained by the Pokhara International Airport (PIA), a total of 957,000 passengers travelled by it and the old Pokhara domestic airport in the year 2023. Among them, 125,000 were foreigners, informed Jashoda Regmi, spokesperson for PIA.

> The number of passengers fell for a few months at the start of last year.

In 2022, 883,536 passengers flew to and from Pokhara, of whom 81,176 were foreign nationals.

The number of passengers fell for a few months at the start of last year because of the January 15 Yeti Air crash. "If the accident had not happened, the number of passengers would have reached 1 million," said Regmi.

Regmi believed that the poor condition of the Pokhara-Mugling Highway and the longer operation hours of the new PIA had also led to the rise in the number of passengers.

Tourist arrival falls 30% in Sagarmatha region

RSS
Salleri (Solukhumbu), Jan 23

Phudoma Sherpa from Khumjung village of Khumbu Pasanglhamu rural municipality-4 in the district is feeling desolate this winter. Although the tourist arrival was normal in the previous years, it is bleak this time, she said. "Last year, tourist influx was normal, but less number of visitors is worrying this winter," she shared.

The Sagarmatha National Park Office at Namche also confirmed that this winter recorded 30 percent fall in tourists' visit in the Sagarmatha region this year. The Khumbu area was visited by 1,920 tourists last year, while only 1,329 turned up this year, according to information officer at Park Office, Manoj Kumar Mandal.

Among the total, 455 were domestic tourists while 1,465 foreigners last year. A total of 120 Nepalis and 1,209 foreigners reached the Khumbu region now. Lately, with the rising cold, the Khumbu region has turned bleak. The Park Office informed that the dipping mercury is the reason behind it. This region sees tourist season for six months in a year.

Among these, the Nepali months of Asoj, Kartik and Mangsir are peak times. In the peak season, as many as 1,000 tourists visit the Khumbu region a day, while there are hardly five to seven tourists now, information officer Mandal added. Ward-4 Chairman Laxman Adhikari said the tourism entrepreneurs are free at present. Even the locals have left villages to avoid cold. When it is off-season, the locals also visit new places.

Chief of Area Administration Office, Namche, Sujan Kumari Bardewa, said the places as Lukla, Namche, and Khumjung are now dismal with limited movement of people. Many people go down the hills to escape brutal cold. Public offices also record negligible number of service seekers, Bardewa added.

Teacher at Khumjung Secondary School, Tilak BK, said, "As the winter begins, the people here leave for warm places including Kathmandu and some even have religious visits up to Bodhgaya, India." Most of the Khumbu people stay in Kathmandu during cold.

Attraction of EVs growing, above 5,100 EVs imported in 6 months

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23



The attraction of consumers towards electric vehicles has been increasing over the years. The import of electric vehicles has increased by almost three folds during the first six months of the current fiscal year as compared to the same period last fiscal year.

Electric vehicles worth above Rs. 13 billion have been imported in six first months of the current fiscal year 2023/24. According to the statistics of the Department of Customs, electric vehicles, including four-wheelers and three-wheelers worth Rs. 13.24 billion have been imported during the review period.

During the review period, 5,107 electric cars, jeeps and vans have been imported. Out of them, 1,421 four-wheeler electric vehicles were imported in the month of Poush, while 899 electric vehicles were imported in the month of Mangsir and 656 electric vehicles were imported in the month of Kartik alone.

The country has imported 5,035 three-wheeler electric vehicles worth Rs. 414 million in the six months of the current fiscal year. The government has collected customs revenue of Rs. 5.84 billion while importing 5,107 electric four-wheelers and 5,035 three-wheelers during the review period.

The electric vehicles with 51 kW to 100 kW capacity are the most imported. A total of 2,970 electric vehicles with the capacity of 51 kW to 100 kW have been imported during the review period. Similarly, 2,056 electric vehicles with motor power up to 50 kW have been imported.

The number of electric vehicles with more than 101 kW to 200 kW motor power is 68 and above 201 kW is 13. During the review period, about 1,273 unassembled electric three-wheelers worth Rs. 148 million have been imported.

The import of electric cars, jeeps and vans has increased significantly during the first six months of the current fiscal year as compared to the same period last fiscal year. The country had imported only 1,749 electric cars, jeeps and vans worth Rs. 4.92 billion during the first six months of the last fiscal year 2022/23.

According to the statistics of the Department of Customs, in the fiscal year 2020/21, a total of 249 four-wheel electric vehicles (cars, jeeps) were imported while 1,800 four-wheeler electric vehicles (car, jeep) were imported in the fiscal year 2021/22 and 4,050 in the fiscal year 2022/23.

Around 6,914 assembled three-wheeler EVs and 459 unassembled three-wheeler EVs were imported in the fiscal year 2022/23. Similarly, around 6,400 three-wheeler EVs were imported in the fiscal year 2021/22 and 4,250 three-wheeler EVs in 2020/21.

The attraction of people towards the EV with capacity of 51 kW to 100 kW is higher than others. The government is currently imposing only 10 per cent customs duty on the import of electric vehicles of up to 50 kW capacity.

According to the new arrangement in the budget, the customs duty on electric vehicles between 50 and 100 kilowatts has been increased by 5 per cent to 15 per cent. Apart from that, 10 per cent excise duty has also been levied.

MoU signed for environment-friendly cement production

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan 23

A memorandum of understanding (MoU) has been signed seeking the future for environment through cement industries operating in Nepal by checking the amount of carbon emission from these industries.

The Department of Mines and Geology and the Cement Producers' Association signed the MoU in this connection with the Technology and Action for Rural Advancement (TARA) on Monday evening. The MoU is related to production of cement in Nepal using the limestone calcine soil technology.

Director-general at the Department Ram Prasad Ghimire, Association president Dhruba Thapa and TARA vice-chairman Soumen Maite signed the MoU in the witness of secretary duo at the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies, Mukunda Prasad Niraula and Narayan Prasad Sharma Duwadi.

Carbon emission can be reduced by 40 percent and the consumption of coal is also decreased when cement is produced by using the limestone calcine soil, said Director-general Ghimire. The Swiss Development Cooperation has supported this technology.

Senior geologist at the Department, Narayan Baskota said this technology was launched in Switzerland in 2013 and it is introduced in Nepal only recently. Large amount of money spent in importing coal for the cement industries can be saved with the use of this technology, it is said.

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Total Amount	:	4,294,566,751.66
No. of Share	:	11,801,360

PAK-AFGHAN TRADE RESUMES AFTER TORKHAM BORDER CROSSING OPENS

AP
Pakistan, Jan. 23

Trade between Pakistan and Afghanistan resumed Tuesday after the two sides reopened a key northwestern border crossing shut for more than 10 days.

Truckers for years have been able to cross the border without documents, so they generally do not have them. But Pakistan began mandating truck drivers get visas last week.

The two sides after a series of meetings agreed to reopen the Torkham border crossing but Pakistan set a new deadline of March 31 for the truck drivers to get visas, said Ziaul Haq Sarhadi, a director of the Pakistan-Afghanistan joint Chamber of Commerce and Industry.

Abdul Basir Zabali, the Taliban-appointed spokesman for the police chief in Nangarhar province, said the Torkham crossing was reopened after the two sides talked, but he didn't give details.

Sri Lankan lawmakers debate controversial internet safety bill

AP
Sri Lanka, Jan.23

Sri Lankan lawmakers on Tuesday began debating a controversial internet safety bill that has been criticized by opposition politicians, journalists and rights groups as a move by the government to stifle freedom of speech.

Public Security Minister Tiran Alles introduced the bill in Parliament, saying it seeks to address problems related to online fraud, abuse and false statements that threaten national security and stability.

He said the laws are necessary to deal with offenses committed online, noting that last year more than 8,000 such complaints were filed with police related to sexual abuse, financial scams, cyber harassment, data theft and other offenses.

However, media, internet and civil rights groups say the bill would have "a chilling effect on free speech," as several provisions would serve to undermine human rights and freedom of expression. The groups have demanded that the government withdraw the bill.

Lawmakers are expected to vote on the bill on Wednesday.

The bill aims to establish an online safety commission with "wide-ranging powers to restrict free speech" that could direct users, service providers and others to "take down content and block access to accounts on extremely vague and overbroad grounds," said Article 19, a rights watchdog, and 50 other groups.

Opposition lawmaker Rauff Hakeem said the government is trying to throttle freedom of speech in Sri Lanka, adding that "a very oppressive environment is going to be created."

"This is a manifestation of a government which is trying to dismantle even the remaining few safeguards for freedom of expression in this country and to destroy democracy," Hakeem said.

Alles rejected the accusations, saying the bill was not drafted with the intention of harassing media or political opponents.

Debate over the bill comes as Sri Lanka struggles to emerge from its worst economic crisis, which hit the island nation two year ago. The country declared bankruptcy in April 2022 with more than $83 billion in debt, more than half of it to foreign creditors.

The crisis caused severe shortages of food, fuel and other necessities. Strident public protests led to the ouster of then-President Gotabaya Rajapaksa. The IMF agreed last March to a $2.9 billion bailout package.

Under new President Ranil Wickremesinghe, the severe shortages of food, fuel and medicine have largely abated over the past year and authorities have restored power supply. But public dissatisfaction has grown over the government's effort to increase revenue by raising electricity bills and imposing heavy new income taxes on professionals and businesses.

Media and civil rights groups accuse the government of trying to introduce more repressive laws in an attempt to "suppress the public's right to expression as a narrow effort with the aim of winning the upcoming elections at any cost."

Sri Lanka's presidential and parliamentary elections are likely to be held later this year or early next year.



PHOTO: OFFICE OF THE PRESIDENT OF NEPAL

Attorney General Dr. Dinmani Pokharel submitting the annual report for the fiscal year 2079\080 to President Ramchandra Paudel on Tuesday.

Madhes Agriculture University construction initiated

RSS
Rajbiraj, Jan. 23

Chairman of Janata Samajbadi Party-Nepal, Upendra Yadav, laid a foundation stone to the Madhes Agriculture University here Monday. He expressed happiness over the realisation of the dream to set up an agriculture university, which he argued, would contribute to the economic prosperity of the country.

"I believe the skilled human resources to be produced from this university would help create jobs and prop up economic prosperity," he said, vowing support from his side for the construction of the building.

On the occasion, Chief Minister of Madhes Province, Saroj Kumar Yadav, pledged all sorts of cooperation to ensure finance for completing the undertaking. He encouraged the university people to move ahead with high morale.

Similarly, former chief minister Lal Babu Raut reminded that the decision to establish Agriculture University at Rajbiraj was made when he was the chief minister. He claimed that the endeavour would now be a province's pride project.

Minister for Land Management, Agriculture and Cooperatives, Gobinda Bahadur Neupane, also said it was a matter of pride to have the agriculture university in Saptari. It must be kept in a priority because only agriculture could be a solid base for the prosperity of the province and country.

Vice Chancellor of Madhes Agriculture University, Dr Baidyanath Mahato, informed about the university. A total of 12 buildings would be constructed for the university. The multi-year project has been contracted for the construction at Rs 1 billion.

The construction would cover 26 bighs and 8 katthas of land, it was shared.

Free medical treatment for children under 10 years launched

BY BISHNU PRASHAD POKHREL
Damak, Jan. 23

Koshi Province Government has launched a programme to provide free medical treatment for children aged below 10 years.

Koshi Provincial government has launched the free treatment facility after signing an agreement with Koshi Provincial Hospital and four other private hospitals

Damak Children's Hospital, operating under the support of the Kathmandu Institute of Child Health (KIOC) and led by Dr. Bhagwan Koirala, has been chosen as the primary location for this initiative. The 50-bed children's hospital will offer complimentary treatment to eligible patients based on prescribed criteria.

The selection of KIOC-Damak Children's Hospital in Jhapa marks the exclusive designation of a single facility within the region. Established a few months ago on Damak's Red Cross premises, the hospital specialises in pediatric care. A bilateral agreement was formalised between Dr. Sudha Devkota, Health Secretary, Koshi Province Government, and Dr. Bhagwan Koirala, President of the Kathmandu Institute of Child Health (KIOC), on behalf of the children's hospital.

According to Dr. Jayamani Shrestha, the director of the Children's Hospital, the implementation of the programme is scheduled to commence on January 29. Free treatment will be extended to patients admitted to the emergency room, as well as those referred from district and city hospitals. Dr. Shrestha emphasised the commitment outlined in the agreement and assured that the hospital will actively contribute to the success of the government-initiated programme, striving to mitigate child mortality.

Dr. Shrestha further disclosed that the hospital currently provides free treatment to children who lack financial resources, ensuring that these patients are not turned away. The commitment remains steadfast to fulfilling the hospital's role in supporting the government's programme and addressing the child mortality rate.

Kedar Karki, the Chief Minister of Koshi Province, announced this crucial programme to prevent premature child deaths resulting from financial constraints across the province. Free treatment services will be extended not only to Damak Children's Hospital but also to Biratnagar Provincial Hospital, Birat Teaching Hospital, and Novel Teaching Hospital, emphasising the government's comprehensive approach to child healthcare.

DHIMAL DEVELOPMENT CENTRE ELECTS NEW OFFICE BEARERS

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Urlabari, Jan. 23

Ambar Bahadur Dhimal has been elected the chairman of the Dhimal Development Centre. The seventh national convention of the Centre held on Monday elected Dhimal to the post of chairman.

Similarly, Kedar Dhimal has been elected co-chairman; Barta Bahadur Dhimal, Shanti Devi Dhimal, Giri Raj Dhimal, Rukmini Dhimal and Ganga Maya Dhimal have been elected vice-chairs, Matri Dhimal General Secretary, and Ratna Bahadur Dhimal treasurer.

Likewise, Ajit Kumar Dhimal and Romansi Dhimal have been elected secretaries.

Coordinators of different departments and members have also been elected.

The Dhimals are an ethnic community, who mainly live in Jhapa, Morang and Sunsari. The convention was held on Saturday and Sunday at the Centre's headquarters at Mangalbare, Urlabari.

Preparations for Swasthani Bratakatha completed



PHOTO: KABITA THAPA\ TRN

A glimpse of Shalinadi area.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

Preparations for the month-long religious observation of Shree Swasthani Bratakhata, dedicated to the Hindu goddess Swasthani marked by abstention from food and recitation of the Swastani story have been completed, according to the Shree Madhavnarayan Swasthani Fasting and Salinadi Management Committee.

Nepali Hindus observe the festival by worshipping the goddess Swasthani, fasting for a month and reciting the holy Swasthani book.

Swastathini Bratakhata narrates the story of lord Shiva and goddess Parvati with a side of didacticism to live a virtuous life.

Around 207 women and men have registered their names to observe fasting which begins on Thursday. The number of devotees is expected to rise in the coming days, as devotees observe the fasting four days after the full moon day, said Mijendra Kaji Shrestha, president of the committee.

Nepali Hindus observe the festival by worshipping the goddess Swasthani, fasting for a month and reciting the holy Swasthani book.

The ritual of fasting and recitation of the holy Swastani book is usually observed from one full moon to the consecutive full moon day next month. All preparations have been made for the month-long worship on the bank of the Sali River at Sankhu, about 20 kilometres northeast of Kathmandu, he said.

He said the committee would need over Rs. 2.5 million to organise the fair, manage puja items, colour and repair works. They also need to spend for the management of the journey to fasting devotees, accommodate the volunteers and supply firewood and hay to the devotees.

Expenses required by the devotees to visit Changu Narayan, Pashupati, Panauti, and Pharping have also been managed, he added.

Guthi Sansthan has provided Rs. 200,000 and additional expenses are managed from donations made by the devotees, he said.

The Sali River has a special significance during this fasting, as a sacred healing and wish-fulfilling site. It is believed that the married women who observe the fast will be blessed with a happy conjugal life and the unmarried women are believed to be blessed with suitable marriage partners.

Men and women of all ages observe this month-long fasting wishing for a prosperous life, perpetual luck, and happiness.

NEWS BRIEF

Two picnickers injured in brawl

Biratamod: At least two persons were injured in a scuffle between two separate groups of picnickers at Dhanushkoti in Jhapa on Monday evening.

Two picnickers were injured in the clash that erupted between two separate groups at Domukha, a picnic spot in Dhanushkoti, on the bank of the Mai River in Jhapa.

Following an argument, the picnic group of Hype Hotel in Birtamod and another picnic group of young people from Surunga Bazaar, started fighting at around 5:30 pm. Picnickers in both groups were drunk. Umesh Chaudhary and Deepak Limbu of Birtamod-5 were injured in the brawl, according to the local police office Birtamod.

Chaudhary is admitted to B&C Hospital and Limbu in Birta City Hospital.

They have sustained head injuries. Police have seized Khukuris and helmets used to hit the youths. The police said that alcohol consumption resulted in the fight.

Trial examinee held for fake entry

Kathmandu: The Kathmandu Valley Traffic Police Office has arrested one trail examinee of a two-wheeler along with three admit cards.

The examinee was arrested from Bhaktapur-based Easy Way Trail Centre, one of the government-authorised trail centres on Monday. The arrested fake examinee has been identified as 18-year-old Sijan Puri of Chulachuli-4, Ilam and a temporary resident of Thali, Kathmandu.

He was arrested from the practical examination hall after three separate admit cards were recovered from him.

Puri, who had possessed admission ID with number 9672947, had failed the exam on his first attempt and had been found possessing fake admit cards to appear in the second and third attempts, said SSP Rajendra Bhatta, who is also the spokesperson for the Traffic Police Office.

TRN

Overhead bridge projects left in limbo in Kohalpur



PHOTO: SIRAJ KHAN\ TRN

Loot Bahadur Rawat, mayor of Kohalpur Municipality, inspecting overhead bridge construction.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Nepalgunj, Jan. 23

Projects to construct three overhead bridges in Kohalpur have been abandoned even after preparing a Detailed Project Report (DPR).

The DPR for the overhead bridges in New Road Chowk, Sajha Chowk and High School Chowk in Kohalpor was prepared in 2020 when former Mayor Loot Bahadur Rawat was leading the city.

However, after winning the mayoral election in 2022, Mayor Purna Prasad Acharya conducted a preliminary inspection of the bridge construction sites in the presence of engineers last year.

The construction work has not begun despite including it in the programme and policies of Ward No. 10 and 11 in the Fiscal Year 2022/023 resulting frozen of a budget of Rs. 15 million allocated in the previous fiscal year.

Mayor Acharya had also prioritised the construction of the overhead bridges in his electoral manifesto.

He said that since the municipal budget was not enough for the construction of the bridges, they had requested the provincial and federal governments for the additional budget. He said that though DPR for all three bridges was prepared during the tenure of the previous mayor, the initial inspection carried out for two bridges revealed that the allocated budget was insufficient.

Mayor Acharya informed that the Ministry of Physical Infrastructure had already called for the tender of the bridge construction. Stating that the construction work has not commenced due to a change in design, he informed that it would start once the design and blueprints are revised and approved.

CIVIL AVIATION AUTHORITY OF NEPAL
CORPORATE PLANING AND MONITORING DEPARTMENT
SINAMANGAL, KATHMANDU, NEPAL

Letter of Intent

Date of Publication: January 24, 2024

Pursuant to the clause 27 (2) of Public Procurement Act, 2063, this is to notify all the bidders that the following substantially responsive lowest evaluated bids have been selected to award the contract as per the Invitation for Bids published on The Rising Nepal dated Nov-29, 2023 and Jan-03, 2024.

Name of Contract	Name & Address of Selected Bidder	Bid Amount
Procurement of Installation, Configuration and Commissioning of Internet Services for CAAN and its offices (NCB-02-CPMD-IT-2080/081)	M/S Subisu Cablenet Ltd., Kathmandu	NPR 67,51,937.58 (Including VAT)
The Procurement of IT Equipment for CAAN (NCB-01-CPMD-IT-080/81)	M/S N.P. Trade and Stationary Suppliers, Kathmandu	NPR 41,21,583.34 (Including VAT)

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Your success and happiness lies in you. Resolve to keep happy, and your joy and you shall form an invincible host against difficulties.
-- Helen Keller

EDITORIAL

End Project Delays

One major factor that holds back Nepal's development pace is the inordinate delay and soaring costs in the construction of big projects. These issues have once again come to the fore after Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda virtually inspected the Sikta Irrigation Project and the third phase of the Mahakali Irrigation Project from the action room in his office on Monday. Such delays come at a heavy price that does not limit itself only to administrative upsets but also undermine the nation's prosperity and erode the public trust in the state's ability to execute and oversee the development projects. This requires analysing the meaning of lengthy time spent on one project, budget restrictions, and the demand for a new paradigm shift in management.

The consequences, however, are widespread, as they cover the entire economy and lower the quality of life. As a means of averting such crises, it is important to emphasise that projects should be completed within the first estimated period and budget allocation. Inadequate budget allocations are considered a primary factor that contributes to project delays. Financial limitations inevitably affect both the quality and rate of project implementation. So, a complete reappraisal of budgeting is required. Provisioning of enough funds for the projects is one basic and imperative aspect of a smooth implementation and timely completion.

The Prime Minister's instruction to project heads, who oversee the delivery of tangible outcomes at their sites, is indeed a welcome step, demonstrating that projects must be outcome-based and not merely activity-driven. In addition, the change in work implications towards development and public service can be praised. Encouraging concerned officials to actively perform their duties as public servants, driven by the interests and aspirations of the people is the need of the hour. The directives with project timeline extension reduction and elimination of inappropriate financial pressures show an attempt to complete projects on time without compromising quality.

In the case of the Sikta Irrigation Project, one can notice how scarcity of resources undermines operational speed, thereby emphasising the release of cost-effective use. The project-time horizon as specifiied underlines a proactive attitude in overcoming such barriers and sticking with accepted terms. For a change, recent orders have focused on responsibility, cost-effectiveness, and technology solutions. This is a praiseworthy move towards the redefinition of the project management administration paradigm and improvement in service delivery.

Stakeholders, including government employees, project leaders, and concerned departments, have to work together so that the timely completion of the projects becomes a collective goal. But the success of these challenges is not only an issue of administrative efficiency; it is also crucial for restoring trust in the public, financial stability, and a prosperous future. Nevertheless, it is important to note possible criticism and areas for development. It can be acknowledged that the issue of project delays is complex and cannot be blamed on budgetary limitations alone.

However, a deeper analysis of project management practices, stakeholder connectivity, and external factors is required for a complete, viable solution. Equally strong monitoring systems should back the praiseworthy guidelines to ensure adherence. In conclusion, addressing project delays is not only an administrative issue but a shared responsibility that holds the key to the stability and prosperity of the nation. Performance in this regard should never be compromised and overlooked.

Snares Of Screens

DIXYA POUDEL

A recent study has stated that people tend to view their smartphones even when they are watching movies and shows at home on television or a computer. And since many movies and series are currently released on the streaming platforms directly, it means that they will be competing with smartphones for the attention of the audience.

People are likely to scroll through their phones even during meal times such as lunch breaks, dinners and often at breakfasts. It is understandable that there are emails to be checked and answered and notifications to be responded to so as to keep up social obligations in the virtual sphere. But the fact that users are being addicted to their screens is alarming. Even television which tends to absorb the attention of the viewers deeply is now contending with the smartphone screens. It probably has to do with FOMO i.e. fear of missing out which has social implications, particularly in the young generations.

It doesn't help that social connections have increasingly switched over to the online world that is accessed through screens. Important life events such as graduations, work promotions, marriages and so on are posted online with intriguing captions, prompting numerous likes, comments and shares from viewers. In a way, it has become obligatory to share life events on the internet. However, they often elicit FOMO as viewers feel like they are missing out in life as compared to fellow Facebookers, Instagrammers and TikTokers.

People are more or less aware that social media sites only perpetuate and highlight success, beauty and accomplishments and that behind-the-scenes may tell a different story. And still, they might feel like they are lagging behind due to FOMO. It could even lead to anxiety and depression in the longer term. It is thus necessary to be rational when it comes to the screen perusal. It is said that all that glitters is not gold. Instead of taking online sphere such as social media by face value, it would be better to focus on self-growth whether it is documented online or not.

To tackle toxicity in social media, it can help to create an authentic presence on such networking sites. It could encourage fellow users to be open about their struggles as well. Next time, FOMO lures into a dark nook, make sure to see beyond the picture-perfect and highly curated online lives. And know that comparison isn't healthy for mental and psychological health. In a way, there has to be a distance from comparison generating social media and one's perception of them.

What is more important is self-growth and self-improvement along with real time social interactions and goals instead of being blindsided by dazzles of the online world. What is seen online barely reflects reality as people tend to keep their struggles to themselves. The snares of screens have become quite addictive. As such, FOMO might grasp one's attention at vulnerable times which is why it is essential to regulate time spent online.

More importantly, it could help to take short breaks from online apps through a regulation of screen time. As for the fact that movies and shows on electronic devices are competing with smartphones, perhaps it signifies how tenuous the attention span is becoming among people globally due to the ubiquity of screens.

Need For Revitalising NAM

Yuba Nath Lamsal



The 19th summit of the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) concluded recently in Kampala, capital of Uganda. In the conference held from January 15 to 20, leaders and participants of different member states reviewed the global state of affairs since the 18th NAM Summit and also discussed the role and relevance of the Non-aligned Movement in the present geopolitical context. Nepal's participation in the 19th NAM Summit was at the highest level with Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' leading the delegation. Addressing the 19th NAM summit, Prime Minister Prachanda laid special emphasis on the need for enhancing and expanding the role of non-aligned movement in the present global state of affairs. According to Prachanda, NAM is as relevant as it was during the time of its foundation and the complicated international scenario demands more active role of the NAM movement.

The non-aligned movement was founded at the height of the Cold War between the US-led alliance and the Soviet Union-led Walshaw Pact group. The countries aligned with US-led alliance were called the first world whereas the Soviet Union and countries of its alliance were referred as the Second World. The rest developing and the least developed countries were better understood as the Third World. So the NAM was the organisation or alliance of the Third World countries. In other words, NAM in itself is third alliance. Now the geopolitical connotation has changed especially after the collapse of the Soviet Union and the Warsaw Pact that gave the rise of unipolar world with the United States remaining only super power. The NAM was necessary during the Cold War marked by rivalry between the two super powers as many countries of the 'Third World' could not afford to side with any of the two rival blocs but chose to remain neutral.

Equal partnership

The NAM, therefore, became an appropriate forum for the countries wishing to have equal partnership and friendship with all countries irrespective of their ideological orientation and strategic alignment. But the international situation and scenario are markedly different at present. Now the countries in the world are categorised into two groups - Global North and the Global South. The industrialised and developed countries are understood as the Global North whereas the developing and the least developed countries are referred as the Global South. Now a debate has kicked off in the international fora and academia: Is the NAM necessary in the present situation or is it just a waste of resources, energy and time? Critics are of the view that since such rival strategic alliances do not exist, the NAM has lost its relevance.

When the NAM was founded, many of the countries in Asia, Africa and Latin America were either just liberated or waging national liberation movements against colonial and imperial powers. The principles of the NAM during its founding days were, thus, anti-colonialism and anti-imperialism. These slogans, thus, had an appeal to many countries in the world that had. The NAM, thus, became a common platform for them to push forward their common agendas and concerns. The NAM was founded on the basis of 'Ten Bangdung Principles, which were later modified to five principles of peaceful co-existence or 'Panchasheel'. Thus, NAM was effective during those days. In the changed international scenario, NAM needs to retrospect and make soul-searching what it did, where it failed and what it needs to do in the present context.

Nepal's foreign policy is based on the principle of 'non-alignment. The five principle of peaceful co-existence continue to guide Nepal's foreign policy and diplomacy. The Constitution of the Federal Democratic Republic of Nepal has incorporated these principles as the basic guiding principles of Nepal's foreign policy. This, in itself, is the testament of Nepal's unflinching faith and commitment to the NAM and its principles. Moreover, Nepal's geographic location and geo-political situation also does not allow it to align with any strategic and military alliance. Nepal, thus, strictly adheres to the principles of non-alignment.

> The Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) requires reforms in itself with newer strategies and concepts to work better in coping with the newly emerged international situation.

The five principles of peaceful co-existence or 'Panchsheel' are more important for Nepal as these principles have their original roots in Nepal. Lord Buddha, who was born in Nepal, propounded the 'Panchsheel' consisting of five codes of human conduct and international relations some 2500 year ago. Despite its vigour and significance in the past, the NAM has, definitely, lost its original charm but not its relevance. The NAM has to be remodelled and if necessary, renamed to cater the need of present day reality. Its principles, objectives and functions, too, are required to be modified, which alone can justify its existence and relevance.

The world and international balance of power definitely changed over the years and decades. The world is no longer bipolar nor will the present state of unipolarity stay forever. The world scenario has changed and is will keep on changing, continuously and steadily, which is the law of nature. The nature of international rivalry has changed and so are the players. China has emerged as a formidable challenger in the global power politics. Several other countries are also rising fast as potential global power. The US-led unipolar world order has come under threat. This requires stronger international movements to bring the developing countries together into a common forum for collectively safeguarding their common and shared interests refraining from siding with any of the poles, groups and blocs.

Noble causes

The Non-aligned Movement has a lot more to accomplish in fully realising its noble causes and common goals of peace, justice and democracy. So far as Nepal is concerned, Nepal always champions and defends the core values of the movement. Nepal wants revitalisation of the Non-aligned Movement to achieve its lofty goals in the present world. Nepal knows the value of peace more than others because we, at present, are in the process of institutionalising peace and inclusive democracy, for which the principles of NAM are our principal guidelines.

Nepal is desirous to make NAM a more vibrant and effective international organisation, in which it wants to play an active role. However, Nepal's diplomatic manoeuvring, lately, appears not to have been as effective as it used to be at international forums like NAM and also in the overall conduct of its diplomacy. The Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) requires reforms in itself with newer strategies and concepts to work better in coping with the newly emerged international situation and in achieving the shared objectives of the member countries.

(The author is former ambassador and former chief editor of this daily. lamsalyubanath@gmail.com)

Ram Consecration Ceremony In Ayodhya

Namrata Sharma



INSIGHT

On 22nd January 2024, the Pran Pratishtha or consecration of the newly-built statue of Ram Lalla was carried out in Ayodhya with a lot of fanfare befitting the Hindu worshippers. This ostentatious ceremony was watched by Hindus all over the world. They took part in the worshipping in the Hindu temples by joining their hands during the 'National Temple' rituals that the Indian Prime Minister Modi, the BJP government and the Hindu leaders in India organised. The Hindus worship idols and believe that the idols will be imbibed with divine energy after *pran pratisthan*, the sacred consecration ceremony, which imparts life to the idols.

While Ayodhya is the birthplace of Ram, who is the incarnation of Vishnu who is one of the Hindu Trinity and the main character of Ramayan, Janakpur in eastern Nepal is the birthplace of Sita, another major character of Ramayan and the incarnation of Laxmi. The Ram Janaki Madir was lit up and celebrations commenced there that coincided with the celebrations of the pran pratisthan in Ayodhya. Several Nepali political and religious leaders along with the general devotees of Ram went to Ayodhya for the event. As the tradition goes, Janakpur which is the city of the in-laws of Ram, sent offerings locally known as Bhaar, including jewellery, food, and clothes, to Ayodhya as part of the rituals.

Celebration

As India celebrated Dipawali on Monday in Ayodhya, Janakpur also celebrated Deepawali, and the Hindu Nepalis in different parts of the country joined in. People were glued to the Indian and Nepali TV channels that were telecasting this event throughout the day. The Janaki Sena, a youth group in Janakpur, collected donations in the form of oil, cotton lamps, clay pots for their two hundred and fifty thousand oil-fed lamps for which about 2,500 litres of mustard oil had been collected. While Janakpur and some Hindus of Nepal seem to be as excited about the consecration in Ayodhya as their Indian counterparts, there were questions raised as to the fact that while many statues were shown and talked about during the consecration, there was no mention of Sita. In the Ramayan and the Hindu culture, Ram is never complete without Sita!

In Ayodhya, 1,000 tonnes of sand were collected from different shaktipiths all over India for the world's largest Diya for Ram's consecration. This earthen Diya, also known as Dashrath Deepak, has a circumference of 100 meters. For this, the cotton wicks were made of several quintals of cotton and the oil used to burn the wicks required several tankers of oil. While Ayodhya showcased a huge theatrical Hindu demonstration of this consecration ceremony, there were opposition voices raised from different sectors on the demonstration of power that politics and religion holds in a secular country like India.

According to The Wire online, a group of Indian diaspora organisation issued a joint statement on Monday (22nd January 2023) saying that PM Modi's inauguration of Ayodhya Ram Temple would set a "dangerous precedent." The statement says, "the planned 'consecration' of the temple by PM Modi and other members of the ruling (Bharatiya Janata Party) and RSS (Rastriya Swayamsevak Sangh) stalwarts is a signal that India has moved to the brink of implementing the long-term RSS goals of making India a Hindu Rashtra (state) and replacing the constitution with Manusmriti, a violently Brahminical anti-Dalit and patriarchal ancient Hindu text."

> One of the criticisms is that the "principled distance" between the state and the religion as set out in India's foundation as a secular nation has been made obscure.

The Indian diaspora and analysts all over the world have been expressing concerns that the temple's consecration makes it clear that Hindutva will be at the front and centre of the BJP elections campaign during the upcoming elections in 2024. The power demonstration of the consecration ceremony in Ayodhya and the Hindutva frenzy that has been created is expected to ensure this BJP victory for the third term. Besides the concerns raised about the political agenda of the BJP and RSS, there were several voices raised regarding the process of the consecration and the fact that it was done before the temple construction was completed. The Shankaracharyas in India have several Peeths and are seen as the guardians of the Hindu religion. Among them a few refused to take part during the consecration as they claimed that the whole process of the rituals was not followed.

In a democratic and secular country like India, the theatrical performance of the consecration of the statue of one of the Hindu gods termed by some in a 'National Temple' is a subject of concern. There are questions being raised that the Hindu nationalist groups were 'appropriating' Muslim religious sites. The Supreme Court's verdict of 2019 handed over the land of the Babri Masjid for building the Ram temple. This particular Babri Masjid was demolished by the Hindu nationalists in 1992. Now there are further claims by fundamentalists Hindus on Muslim places of worship in Varanasi and Mathura.

Criticisms

PM Modi faces several criticisms for his active role in inaugurating the temple. One of the criticisms is that the "principled distance" between the state and the religion as set out in India's foundation as a secular nation has been made obscure. While a lot of celebrities, political leaders and thousands of ordinary people came together for the consecration, there was a stark absence of the main opposition leaders and also the 96-year-old veteran BJP leader LK Advani and another veteran BJP leader Murli Manohar Joshi.

Former Indian deputy premier Advani was actually the person who led the Ram Janmabhoomi movement in the 1990s, starting with a rath yatra that culminated in the demolition of the Babri Masjid on December 6th, 1992. The BJP was founded in 1980 with Advani taking the leadership of the Ram Janmabhoomi movement in 1984 before becoming party president in 1986. Since then, BJP has had this agenda which has been realised by PM Modi in a manner which raises questions on whether the Hindus have been spiritually awaked or rather the Indians as a whole have to now start doing a reality check on where they stand as a secular democratic country.

(Sharma is a senior journalist and women rights advocate namrata1964@yahoo.com Twitter handle: @NamrataSharmaP)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 24, 1974

Technical Data Collection To Begin Soon

Kathmandu, Jan 23: Collection of technical data on Karnali project will commence shortly, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Complete Projects Within Deadlines



I am writing this letter with regard to the news '*PM: Stop extending project deadlines*' published by your esteemed paper on Tuesday. The PM's instruction is much welcome because extending projects' deadlines and increasing their costs has become an unfortunate reality in Nepal.

We need only look at Melamchi to understand this. It is good that the highest executive authority of the land has acknowledged this and is seeking to end it.

What matters now is that the government takes the necessary steps to implement the Prime Minister's direction. He has made it clear that delays and budget overruns will not be acceptable so now, subordinate bodies must do the needful to ensure that does not happen. Inordinate delay in the completion of big projects has led to cost overrun and also raised the question regarding the state's capacity to execute the development projects within a given timeframe.

After all, words are only as good as the actions they lead to. Hopefully, the PM's instructions lead to real change on the ground.

Sunil Pokharel
Damak

TAILPIECE

A man walks in a bank, pulls out a gun, and robs the bank... Then he turns around and asks the next customer in line, "Did you see me rob this bank?"

The customer replies, "YES!" The robber raises his gun, points to his head and BANG!!!!!... shoots him in the head and kills him!

He then moves to the next customer in line and says to the man, "DID ... YOU ... SEE ... ME ... ROB THIS BANK????"

The man calmly responds, "No ... But My Wife Did!"

Pentagon has no more money for Ukraine

AP
Washington, Jan. 23



PHOTO: AP

Airmen with the 436th Aerial Port Squadron use a forklift to move 155 mm shells ultimately bound for Ukraine, April 29, 2022, at Dover Air Force Base, Del.

For the first time since Defense Secretary Lloyd Austin established the international group to support Ukraine in April 2022, the United States will host the monthly gathering of about 50 countries out of money, unable to send the ammunition and missiles that Ukraine needs to fend off Russia.

While waiting for Congress to pass a budget and potentially approve more money for Ukraine's fight, the U.S. will be looking to allies to keep bridging the gap. Tuesday's meeting will focus on longer-term needs, deputy Pentagon press secretary Sabrina Singh told reporters Monday.

"Even though we aren't able to provide our security assistance right now, our partners are continuing to do that," Singh said. The meeting will be virtual because Austin is still recuperating at home from complications of treatment for prostate cancer.

The Pentagon announced its last security assistance for Ukraine on Dec. 27, a $250 million package that included 155 mm rounds, Stinger anti-aircraft missiles and other high-demand items drawn from existing U.S. stockpiles.

The U.S. has not been able to provide additional munitions since then because the money for replenishing those stockpiles has run out and Congress has yet to approve more funds.

More than $110 billion in aid for both Ukraine and Israel is stalled over disagreements between Congress and the White House over other policy priorities, including additional security for the U.S.-Mexico border. Meanwhile, Russia has shown no willingness to end its conflict in Ukraine, and on Monday the United Nations ruled out any peace plan backed by Kyiv and the West.

The U.S. has provided Ukraine more than $44.2 billion in security assistance since Russia invaded in February 2022. About $23.6 billion of that was pulled from existing military stockpiles and almost $19 billion was sent in the form of longer-term military contracts, for items that will take months to procure. So even though funds have run out, some previously purchased weapons will continue to flow in. An additional $1.7 billion has been provided by the U.S. State Department in the form of foreign military financing.

The U.S. and approximately 30 international partners are also continuing to train Ukrainian forces, and to date have trained a total of 118,000 Ukrainians at locations around the world, said Col. Marty O'Donnell, spokesman for U.S. Army Europe and Africa.

The United States has trained approximately 18,000 of those fighters, including approximately 16,300 soldiers in Germany. About 1,500 additional fighters are currently going through training.

21 Israeli soldiers killed in single attack

AP
Jerusalem, Jan. 23

Twenty-one soldiers were killed in the Gaza Strip in the deadliest attack on Israel's forces since the Oct. 7 Hamas raid that triggered the war, the military said Tuesday, a major setback that could add to mounting calls for a cease-fire.

Hours later, the military announced that ground forces had encircled the southern city of Khan Younis, Gaza's second largest, where dozens of Palestinians have been killed and wounded in heavy fighting in recent days.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu mourned the soldiers but vowed to press ahead with the offensive until "absolute victory" over Hamas. He has also promised to return over 100 hostages held captive in Gaza. But Israelis are increasingly divided on the question of whether it's possible to do either, and large numbers of Israeli casualties have pressured Israel's government to halt past military operations.

A senior Egyptian official meanwhile said Israel has proposed a two-month cease-fire in which the hostages would be freed in exchange for the release of Palestinians imprisoned by Israel and top Hamas leaders in Gaza would be allowed to relocate to other countries.

The official, who was not authorized to brief media and spoke on condition of anonymity, said Hamas rejected the proposal and is insisting that no more hostages will be released until Israel ends its offensive and withdraws from Gaza. Israel's government declined to comment on the talks.

The official said Egypt and Qatar, which have brokered past agreements between Israel and Hamas, were developing a multistage proposal to try and bridge the gaps. Families of the hostages have called for Israel to reach a deal with Hamas, saying time is running out to bring the hostages home alive.

On Monday, Israeli reservists were preparing explosives to demolish two buildings in central Gaza when a militant fired a rocket-propelled grenade at a tank nearby. The blast triggered the explosives, causing both two-story buildings to collapse on the soldiers inside.

At least 217 soldiers have been killed since the ground offensive began in late October, including three killed in a separate event Monday, according to the military.

Netanyahu acknowledged it was "one of the hardest days" since the war began and said the military would launch an investigation. "In the name of our heroes, and for our own lives, we will not stop fighting until absolute victory," he wrote on X, formerly known as Twitter.

Israel launched its offensive after Hamas crossed the border Oct. 7, killed over 1,200 people and abducted some 250 others. More than 100 were released in November in exchange for a week-long cease-fire and the release of 240 Palestinians imprisoned by Israel.

The offensive has caused widespread destruction, displaced an estimated 85% of Gaza's population and left over 25,000 Palestinians dead, according to health officials in the Hamas-run territory.

The United Nations and international aid agencies say the fighting has caused a humanitarian disaster, with a quarter of Gaza's 2.3 million people facing starvation.

RUSSIA TARGETS KYIV, KHARKIV IN UKRAINE

AP
Kyiv, Ukraine, Jan. 23

Russian missiles targeted Ukraine's two biggest cities on Tuesday morning, damaging apartment buildings and killing at least six people after Moscow shunned any deal to end the almost two-year war that is backed by Kyiv and its Western allies.

The Russian barrage included more than 40 ballistic, cruise, anti-aircraft and guided missiles, officials said.

It injured at least 20 people in four districts of Kyiv, the capital, including a 13-year-old boy, according to Mayor Vitalii Klitschko.

In Kharkiv, in northeast Ukraine, the onslaught injured 42 people as the missiles damaged around 30 residential buildings and shattered nearly a thousand apartment windows in icy weather, regional Gov. Oleh Syniehubov said.

Kharkiv Mayor Ihor Terekhov said the temperature in the city was minus 7 Celsius (19 Fahrenheit).

An entire section of a multi-story residential building was destroyed, trapping an unknown number of people there, Terekhov said.

Lying about 30 kilometres (18 miles) from the border with Russia, Kharkiv has often felt the brunt of Russia's winter campaign of long-range strikes that commonly hit civilian areas.

The attacks keep Ukrainians on edge while the 1,500-kilometre front line has barely budged.

US, Britain launch new round of strikes against Houthis in Yemen

AP
Washington, Jan. 23



PHOTO: AP

A Royal Air Force Typhoon FGR4 is prepared to take off to carry out air strikes against Houthi military targets in Yemen, from RAF Akrotiri, Cyprus, Monday, Jan. 22, 2024.

The U.S. and British militaries bombed multiple targets in eight locations used by the Iranian-backed Houthis in Yemen on Monday night, the second time the two allies have conducted coordinated retaliatory strikes on an array of the rebels' missile-launching capabilities.

According to officials, the U.S. and U.K. used warship- and submarine-launched Tomahawk missiles and fighter jets to take out Houthi missile storage sites, drones and launchers. The officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss a military operation, said Australia, Bahrain, Canada and the Netherlands contributed to the mission, including with intelligence and surveillance.

In a joint statement, the six allied nations said the strikes specifically targeted a Houthi underground storage site and locations associated with the Houthis' missile and air surveillance capabilities. They added, "Our aim remains to de-escalate tensions and restore stability in the Red Sea, but let us reiterate our warning to Houthi leadership: we will not hesitate to defend lives and the free flow of commerce in one of the world's most critical waterways in the face of continued threats."

Britain's Ministry of Defense confirmed that four Royal Air Force Typhoon jets struck "multiple targets at two military sites in the vicinity of Sanaa airfield" with precision-guided bombs. The strikes, said Defense Secretary Grant Shapps, were "aimed at degrading Houthi capabilities" and would "deal another blow to their limited stockpiles and ability to threaten global trade."

One senior U.S. military official told reporters the strikes dropped between 25 and 30 munitions and hit multiple targets in each location, adding that the U.S. "observed good impacts and effects" at all sites, including the destruction of more advanced weapons in the underground storage facility. The official said this is the first time such advanced weapons were targeted.

The official also said fighter jets from the USS Dwight D. Eisenhower aircraft carrier conducted strikes, and other ships involved included the USS Gravely and USS Mason, both naval destroyers, and the USS Philippine Sea, a cruiser.

The joint operation comes about 10 days after U.S. and British warships and fighter jets struck more than 60 targets in 28 locations. That was the first U.S. military response to what has been a persistent campaign of Houthi drone and missile attacks on commercial ships since the start of the Israel-Hamas war in October.

PRISM

Baby born at side of New Jersey road

New Jersey: A healthy baby girl was born at the side of a New Jersey road with help from a police officer in the midst of a winter storm.

The Sparta Police Department said Officer Christopher Botta responded to a report of a woman in labour at the side of Route 15, near the city's border with Jefferson.

Botta located the vehicle stopped at the side of the road and made contact with expecting parents Tyler and Stephanie.

"Officer Botta observed the baby's head crowning and proceeded to ensure the umbilical cord was not wrapped around the baby's neck," the department said in a news release.

Dog helps rescue Michigan man

Michigan: A Michigan man who fell through the ice into a frigid lake can thank the efforts of his obedient dog for his successful rescue, Michigan State Police said.

The MSP said in a news release that Motor Carrier Officer Kammeron Bennetts responded to a call reporting a 65-year-old Traverse City man had fallen through the ice into Arbutus Lake in East Bay Township.

Bennetts had a rescue disc in his car, but was unable to reach the man due to the conditions of the ice.

The man's dog, Ruby, was on the ice next to the hole made by her owner, and the man sent the canine over to Bennetts.

(AP)

AI-generated robocall impersonates Biden

AP
New Hampshire, Jan. 23



PHOTO: AP

President Joe Biden speaks in the East Room, Jan. 19, 2024, in Washington.

The New Hampshire attorney general's office on Monday said it was investigating reports of an apparent robocall that used artificial intelligence to mimic President Joe Biden's voice and discourage voters in the state from coming to the polls during Tuesday's primary election.

Attorney General John Formella said the recorded message, which was sent to multiple voters on Sunday, appears to be an illegal attempt to disrupt and suppress voting. He said voters "should disregard the contents of this message entirely."

A recording of the call reviewed by The Associated Press generates a voice similar to Biden's and employs his often-used phrase, "What a bunch of malarkey." It then tells the listener to "save your vote for the November election."

"Voting this Tuesday only enables the Republicans in their quest to elect Donald Trump again," the voice mimicking Biden says. "Your vote makes a difference in November, not this Tuesday."

It is not true that voting in Tuesday's primary precludes voters from casting a ballot in November's general election. Biden is not campaigning in New Hampshire and his name will not appear on Tuesday's primary ballot after he elevated South Carolina to the lead-off position for the Democratic primaries, but his allies are running a write-in campaign for him in the state.

It's not known who is behind the calls, though they falsely showed up to recipients as coming from the personal cellphone number of Kathy Sullivan, a former state Democratic Party chair who helps run Granite for America, a super-PAC supporting the Biden write-in campaign.

Sullivan said she alerted law enforcement and issued a complaint to the attorney general after multiple voters in the state reported receiving the call Sunday night.

"This call links back to my personal cell phone number without my permission," she said in a statement. "It is outright election interference, and clearly an attempt to harass me and other New Hampshire voters who are planning to write-in Joe Biden on Tuesday."

It was unclear how many people received the call but a spokesperson for Sullivan said she heard from at least a dozen people who received it. The attorney general's office encouraged anyone who has received the call to email the state Justice Department's election law unit. Gail Huntley, a 73-year-old Democrat in Hancock, New Hampshire, who plans to write in Biden's name on Tuesday, said she received the call at about 6:25 p.m. on Sunday.

She instantly recognized the voice as belonging to Biden but quickly realized it was a scam because what he was saying didn't make sense. Initially, she figured his words were taken out of context.

"I didn't think about it at the time that it wasn't his real voice. That's how convincing it was," she said, adding that she is appalled but not surprised that AI-generated fakes like this are spreading in her state.

White House press secretary Karine Jean-Pierre confirmed Monday that the call "was indeed fake and not recorded by the president." Biden's campaign manager, Julie Chavez Rodriguez, said in a statement that the campaign is "actively discussing additional actions to take immediately."

"Spreading disinformation to suppress voting and deliberately undermine free and fair elections will not stand, and fighting back against any attempt to undermine our democracy will continue to be a top priority for this campaign," she said.

The apparent attempt at voter suppression using rapidly advancing generative AI technology is one example of what experts warn will make 2024 a year of unprecedented election disinformation around the world.

Generative AI deepfakes already have appeared in campaign ads in the 2024 presidential race, and the technology has been misused to spread misinformation in multiple elections across the globe over the past year, from Slovakia to Indonesia and Taiwan.

"We have been concerned that generative AI would be weaponized in the upcoming election and we are seeing what is surely a sign of things to come," said Hany Farid, an expert in digital forensics at the University of California, Berkeley, who reviewed the call recording and confirmed it is a relatively low-quality AI fake.

TODAY IN HISTORY

41 – Claudius is proclaimed Roman emperor by the Praetorian Guard after they assassinate the previous emperor, his nephew Caligula.
1742 – Charles VII Albert becomes Holy Roman Emperor.
1817 – Crossing of the Andes: Many soldiers of Juan Gregorio de las Heras are captured during the action of Picheuta.
1835 – Slaves in Salvador da Bahia, Brazil, stage a revolt, which is instrumental in ending slavery there 50 years later.
1848 – California Gold Rush: James W. Marshall finds gold at Sutter's Mill near Sacramento.
1857 – The University of Calcutta is formally founded as the first fully fledged university in South Asia.
1859 – The United Principalities of Moldavia and Wallachia (later named Romania) is formed as a personal union under the rule of Domnitor Alexandru Ioan Cuza.
1900 – Second Boer War: Boers stop a British attempt to break the Siege of Ladysmith in the Battle of Spion Kop.



PHOTO: RSS

A collective cow farming in Barbote of Ilam Municipality -6.

GOVT LAUNCHES SOCIAL MEDIA COMPLAINT SYSTEM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

The government has set up an online system to register complaints of social media misuse. Earlier on November 27 last year, the federal government had issued guidelines to regulate social media.

As per the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology (MoCIT), the online complaint registration system has been developed under those guidelines. It has also established a social network management unit under Undersecretary Ramesh Pandeya to handle the complaints received.

Complaints can be registered by clicking on the 'Social Platform Complaint Registration' section on MoCIT's website or by directly going to https://mocit.gov.np/socialplatformcomplaint. Pandeya informed that the ministry would study the complaints and forward those related to cyber-crimes to the Nepal Police and send those requiring attention from the platform to the relevant social media company.

Doctors halt services over unpaid salaries

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gaur, Jan. 23



Doctors at Gaur Provincial Hospital have halted outpatient services to stage a protest against the non-payment of their salaries, resulting in critical consequences for patients.

Doctors, who have not received their salaries for the past three months, decided to halt all services, except for emergency care, leaving patients in distress. Despite tirelessly providing round-the-clock care, the medical staff expressed their inability to continue services as of January 21 due to the persistent non-payment of wages, salaries and allowances.

Addressing the issue, the doctors emphasised that in a sensitive sector such as healthcare, political interference for personal gain should be avoided. Unfortunately, Gaur Provincial Hospital has been grappling with political interference for over six months, adversely affecting the entire healthcare system, as stated in a press release by the medical professionals .

The prolonged political interference has led to a six-month delay in the disbursement of allowances to all health workers. Consequently, beneficiaries including ambulance services, hearse services, and maternal protection allowances, among others, have been severely impacted.

In light of this crisis, both service providers and recipients have tolerated the effect of the situation. Until their demands are met, the doctors, led by Gopal Gupta, have decided to suspend all services at Gaur Provincial Hospital, except for emergency care. The healthcare community urges that the issues raised by the protesting doctors should be immediately addressed, to ensure the well-being of both medical professionals and patients.

Border development scheme of APF on high priority of govt

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the border development and improvement programme of the Armed Police Force Nepal (APF) will be accorded top priority.

Addressing a function organised on the 23rd establishment year of the Armed Police Force at Halchowk on Tuesday, Prime Minister Prachanda said that he was aware of the contribution made by the armed forces for the security and self-respect of the country.

"I am confident that the programme carried out by the APF in the field of border security and management will make a qualitative contribution to the country's self-respect and border security by addressing the existing problems and challenges," said PM Prachanda.

The government is committed to advancing the border development programme and its improvement proposed by the institution giving it a top priority, he added.

Stating that the PM is aware that the APF is carrying out all the responsibilities given to the institution with indomitable courage, honesty and professionalism, the Prime Minister said, "In addition to border security, APF's contribution to revenue collection and its leakage control, security of important people and structures, internal security, law enforcement, peace, security, and freedom in the country is also equally notable and crucial."

PM Prachanda said the force has been given some new responsibilities recently in addition to the responsibilities it received in the past.

He also said that the government would give high priority to the morale development of officers and soldiers, service facilities, security and equip them with needed weapons and other logistical materials.

On the occasion of the anniversary, he extended his heartiest congratulations to all the family members and units of the force who were honoured with the APF Life Time Achievement Award, APF Special Honour and Best Brigade Running Trophy.

Various cultural shows, APF drills from the music bands and sporting events were showcased on the occasion.

Minister Sharma calls for digital transformation plan

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan 23

Minister for Communications and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that the 16th periodic plan should be made a plan for digital transformation.

Minister Sharma has asked the National Planning Commission (NPC) to forward the activities of digital infrastructure with priority.

During a discussion meeting between the Ministry and NPC at the Ministry on Tuesday, Minister Sharma said that time has come to centre the state's priority and investment in the information technology sector as country's prosperity was not likely without digital transformation.

She said that the upcoming plan should be made by confirming the priorities of all ministries and agencies to implement the Digital Nepal Framework. "A lot can be done in the making of Digital Nepal if we advance all areas at once," Minister Sharma argued.

On the occasion, Minister Sharma pointed out that poor mentality and planning resulted in underdevelopment in the country rather than insufficient budget. For this, the concept of project bank should be advanced with the clear modality of investment from the government, donors, public and other resources.

Next year's...

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat underscored the positivity of external economic indicators but noted that the anticipated success in revenue collection had not been realized. He advocated for a cautious and economical approach in light of these challenges.

Dr. Baikunth Aryal, Chief Secretary of the Government of Nepal, highlighted the revised schedule for policy, programme and budget creation, anticipating that this adjustment would facilitate a thorough study and discussion process, leading to more informed decisions.

During the meeting, Finance Secretary Dr. Krishna Hari Pushkar and other departmental heads of the Ministry of Finance presented an overview of the current state of the economy.

Expedite works...

"Not only will it generate electricity, the reservoir will help fill the gap in supply seen between monsoon and winter. It will also contribute to tourism, fishery, infrastructure development and employment generation. It will benefit the national economy immensely. All of us must understand this."

Chief Secretary of the Government of Nepal Dr. Baikuntha Aryal informed that the government had allocated Rs. 5 from the Rs. 10 infrastructure tax it levies on each litre of petrol and diesel sold to Budhigandaki.

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Defence Purna Bahadur Khadka and Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma were also present at the discussion.

Bagmati Corridor monuments...

The third phase involved the restoration of four monuments, and this was completed on March 31, 2023, for Rs. 437 million.

She added, "All the reconstruction work was accomplished using traditional methods, employing materials such as lime, sand, surkhi, molasses, and black lentil. As a result, each structure now appears exactly as it did originally."

Pokharel noted, "Following the completion of the reconstruction of 28 monuments, the critical issue lies in operational management. While certain structures have been handed over to guthis, others remain to be handed over. The Kathmandu Metropolitan City should take on the responsibility for oversight. However, it has not shown any concern in this regard thus far."

Pokharel said that the completed structures are not currently in use. She mentioned efforts to meet with Mayor Balen Shah of KMC, which were unsuccessful. Instead, they approached Deputy Mayor Sunita Dangol, urging her to visit the site and proceed with further plans for the structures. However, as of now, there has been no communication or progress in this regard.

She said that the potential for these areas to serve as tourist attractions and generate revenue. She added that the sole objective of the project is make the corridor clean and to witness these monuments being utilised like before for their historical purposes.

According to Nepal, the Management Action Plan has been submitted to the KMC, but there has been no response in return. He emphasized that these structures are assets of guthis and should be utilsed for the purposes for which they were originally constructed.

These monuments are located in Wards 11 and 12 of the KMC. He expressed the desire to promote the local culture and address the environmental impact as these structures within the corridor contribute to its being unhealthy and untidy.

The reconstructed monuments include Karki Sattal, Manandhar Sattal, Shiva Temple, Munsi Ghat Sattal, Pujari Sattal, Rajbhandari Sattal, Purohit Ghat Sattal, Panchanari Ghat Sattal, West Sattal, Teen Dewal Temple Gateway to Bomkiteswar, Bairagi Sattal, Kalmochan Ghat Sattal (Block V), and Udashi Sattal.

All these monuments, including Chaughera Sattals, are adorned with intricately carved wooden structures, featuring elements such as carved pillars, windows, balconies, doors, and other architectural embellishments like struts and tympanums.

KMC bans vehicle parking...

He said, "For now, we have been consulting with vehicle owners and requesting compliance with the rules without immediate fines. However, in the future, legal actions will be taken against those violating the rule." He further informed that the KMC would impose a fine of Rs. 1,000 on two-wheelers and padlock four-wheelers, taking them to the traffic office for further action if they are found in violation.

The KMC informed that it had made arrangements of free parking facility at Kathmandu Tower (current old bus park) where 300 four-wheelers and 700 two-wheelers could be parked.

Additionally, as part of efforts to make the city cleaner and visually appealing, the KMC conducted a special cleanliness drive in the parking-prohibited area on Tuesday morning.

The traders, however, resorted to a symbolic protest against parking ban for an hour and kept the shutters down.

Construction work of Siddhababa...

In addition to the tunnel construction, work has begun to build a 'rock shed' to mitigate the risk of falling rocks. A 780-metre 'rock shed' is being constructed to prevent landslides and the falling of hard rocks from the Siddhartha Highway, the construction company said.

The construction of bypass tunnels is starting at three different locations. Sabita Gyawali, the Project Information Officer, said that three 431-metre bypass tunnels, leading to the tunnel area, are currently under excavation. The tunnel construction is progressing from the lower gate, while additional structures are being built in the upper section.

Approval has been obtained from the relevant authorities to cut 30 trees in the area designated for the construction of the rock shed. Once the tree-cutting process is completed, the construction of the rock shed will also be accelerated, she said.

In addition to the tunnel road, the company received a task of upgrading 904 metres toward Butwal and 1,494 metres toward Palpa. The estimated cost for completing the entire tunnel project is Rs. 7.34 billion.

For a long time, travellers have been demanding the construction of a tunnel to avoid the mishaps caused by landslides in this area.

Ram Bahadur Raut, a resident of Tinau-2, Dobhan, said that after the construction of the tunnel, it will be easier to reach Palpa, Rupandehi, Gulmi, Arghakhanchi, Syangja, Pokhara, Baglung and other areas.

Locals believe that the tunnel will play an important role in the economic development of Rupandehi, Lumbini, Palpa, Kaski, Gulmi and Arghakhanchi districts.

Regional disarmament meeting begins in Kathmandu

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

The Regional Preparatory Meeting for the Fourth Review Conference on the United Nations Programme of Action to Prevent, Combat and Eradicate the Illicit Trade in Small Arms and Light Weapons (SALW) in All Its Aspects (UN PoA) and its International Tracing Instrument (ITI) kicked off in Kathmandu on Tuesday. The event will run until Thursday, 25 January.

The meeting is attended by delegations from over 25 countries including the President Designate of the Fourth Review Conference, Maritza Chan Valverde of Costa Rica, and Izumi Nakamitsu, UN Under-Secretary-General and High Representative for Disarmament Affairs.

The UN PoA, established in 2001 at the UN General Assembly, is a critical, politically binding framework. It encompasses commitments by Member States to enhance control measures over small arms, including through improved national regulations, stockpile management, import/export controls, and international cooperation, the United Nations Nepal Office informed in a statement.

According to it, the introduction of the ITI in 2005 further strengthened this framework, by emphasizing the need for effective marking and record-keeping of weapons, thus aiding in their traceability.

These measures are integral to the global effort in addressing the challenges posed by the illicit arms trade and align with the objectives of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

UN Member States periodically review progress on these commitments, with the Fourth Review Conference (RevCon4) scheduled from 17 – 28 June 2024 in New York. A Preparatory Committee meeting (PrepCom) to lay the groundwork for that meeting will take place from 12 to 16 February.

In anticipation of RevCon4, the United Nations Regional Centre for Peace and Disarmament in Asia and the Pacific (UNRCPD), in collaboration with the Government of Nepal, is organising the preparatory regional meeting in Kathmandu.

"The regional meeting will provide a forum for participating States and other stakeholders, including civil society organisations, to identify region-specific SALW-related challenges and discuss priorities for RevCon4," read the statement.

Addressing the review conference, Minister for Foreign Affairs of Nepal, NP Saud, said that the members should focus on four priority areas – strengthening national capacities, actively promoting regional initiatives to address the armed-related challenges, adapting strategies and regulations to counter threats posed by homemade firearms, and engage women, youth, civil society and private sector in the initiative.

According to him, since the adoption of the Programme of Action, several initiatives have been taken at the global, regional, national and local levels to address the illicit trade and use of small arms and light weapons in all its aspects.

These efforts encompass a spectrum of measures, ranging from strengthening of legal frameworks, enhancing border controls, fostering international cooperation and collaboration in exchanging information.

"However, in more than two decades of the adoption of the Programme of Action, the illicit trade and use of small arms and light weapons persists as a widespread security challenge. In fact, the gravity of this issue appears more pronounced than ever," said the Foreign Minister.

Whatever the reason, the reality is that we are yet to grasp the essence and momentum of the Programme of Action, maintained FM Saud.

"In the context of Nepal, we are dealing this issue with a careful and concerted effort. Nepal's commitment to disarmament is total and unequivocal. It is one of the objectives of Nepal foreign policy as well," he stated.

The three-day meeting will feature thematic presentations and group discussions on various themes, such as developing effective national policies, enhancing tracing of small arms and light weapons through the ITI framework, and identifying and developing strategies to curb the supply and demand of SALW.

According to the UN, the meeting, it also offers a unique opportunity for participating States and regional organizations of Asia-Pacific to engage in constructive discussions on combating terrorism, illicit trafficking, and transnational crimes within the framework of the PoA, and contribute to countries' mandatory national reports.

Janamat Party quits its support to Madhes govt

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Janakpur, Jan. 23

Janamat Party, one of the ruling coalition parties in the centre and provinces, has withdrawn its support given to the Madhes Province Government.

A letter submitted to Province Chief Hari Shankar Mishra by a delegation led by the parliamentary party leader of Janamat Party and Education and Culture Minister of the Madhes Government, Mahesh Prasad Yadav on Tuesday read that the party withdrew its support given to the government of Chief Minister Saroj Kumar Yadav effective from Tuesday itself.

It is believed that the party decided to quit the government after Minister Yadav and Janamat Party's Assembly member Satish Kumar Yadav were injured in a police clash during a demonstration held by the party in Saptari on Monday.

The clash erupted when Janata Samajwadi Party chairman Upendra Yadav reached there to lay the foundation stone of the Agriculture University.

Army's photo and unit-centric exhibition kicks off

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23



The Nepali Army has organised a photo and unit-centric exhibition at the Army Headquarters on the occasion of an upcoming Army Day.

Chief of the Army Staff (CoAS) General Prabhu Ram Sharma inaugurated the exhibition with photographs, weapons, and equipment reflecting the activities of the army from the past to the present amidst a special function organised on Tuesday.

The exhibition will last for five days.

Visitors gracing the exhibition can get information about military uniforms, bands, air service, cavalry, forest and mountain warfare, Special Forces, national parks and wildlife reserves, and peacekeeping missions.

Development, construction, disaster management, sports and military schools and other activities and audio-visual materials run by the army are included in the exhibition. The Directorate of Public Relations and Information (DPR&I) of the Army Headquarters is coordinating the exhibition, according to Brigadier General and Spokesperson for the Army Headquarters Krishna Prasad Bhandari.

The exhibition is organised to provide the citizens with the opportunity to closely observe the various activities related to the army until January 27 from 10:00 a.m. to 5:00 pm. The exhibition aims to provide information about various activities of the Nepal Army.

Director of DPR&I Bhandari expressed his belief that the general citizens will get information about arms, clothing and related military materials from the exhibition which includes the main work done in the course of duty, covering the glorious history of the army.

Meanwhile, in the photo competition organised by the Nepali Army on the same occasion, the Ramban Company was declared first, the Special Forces Brigade the second and the Srimehar Battalion the third.

In the competition, the No. 17 Brigade, Ranasher Battalion, Khadgadal Battalion, Bhawani Box Battalion, Arjunban, Bhagwati Dal Battalion and Military School, Pokhara received consolation prizes.

Siddhartha Maharjan won the first, Safal Prakash Shrestha won the second and Varsha Shah won the third prize in the non-military category photo competition. Chief of Army Staff Sharma awarded cash prizes and certificates to them.

Biraj draws over 2000 arts in leaves

BY NETRA SHAHI
Jumla, Jan. 23



Biraj Bhandari, a 24-year-old man from Chandannath Municipality 2 in Jumla, possesses the unique skill of drawing pictures and shapes on leaves. He has, of late, found a way to turn his passion into a source of income by adding his name to these creations.

Formerly a participant in art competitions, Biraj now revels in crafting shapes of people and various objects on leaves.

He attributes the development of this skill to the time he spent on YouTube during the 2020 lockdown.

While learning, he also took part in art competitions, achieving commendable results, and has been immersed in leaf art for the past two years.

His inspiration stemmed from encountering an image of the Taj Mahal on a leaf, which he replicated and expanded into a series of leaf drawings.

Initially, his focus was on drawing maps of Nepal, but over time, he has integrated the practice of shaping leaves into his daily routine.

Biraj has now extended his artistry to depicting figures of different people and significant places, having completed around 2,000 to 2,500 pages of such artwork.

Encouraged by positive feedback on social media, Biraj has continued to refine his leaf art and has transitioned to earning money for his creations.

He mentioned that he began earning over Rs. 1, 000 by drawing on a single leaf.

In addition to his artistic pursuits, Biraj holds a teaching position at Karnali Technical College.

Tekendra Thapa, the head of Karnali Technical School, praised Biraj Bhandari's proficiency in drawing pictures and shapes on leaves.

Notably, Biraj has recently depicted figures of prominent individuals including Kulman Ghising, Balendra Shah and Laxmi Prasad Devkota on leaves.

The primary canvas for Biraj's paintings comprises peepal and banana leaves.

Bham's 'Shambhala' selected for Berlin International Film Festival



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

Min Bahadur Bham's film 'Shambhala' has officially been selected for the Berlin International Film Festival, making it the first Nepali feature film to achieve this feat.

Bham's film has been chosen in the international film category for the 74th edition of the Berlin Festival, which is considered one of the world's top three and most prestigious film festivals.

Organising a press conference in Lalitpur on Monday, the film unit officially announced the news and unveiled the film's poster.

Earlier, Bham made history with the first-ever entry from Nepal as his short film 'Bansulli' was selected for the Venice Film Festival. His film 'Kalo Pothi' achieved recognition by clinching the Best Film Award at the 72nd Venice Film Festival, Critics Week.

The film 'Shambhala' narrates the compelling story of a pregnant woman in a remote Himalayan village who embarks on a journey with her brother-in-law after her husband abandons her.

Written by Bham and Avinash Vikram Shah, the film is produced under the banner of Suny Films.

'Shambhala' features a talented cast including Thinley Lhamo, Sonam Topden and Tenzing Dalha in lead roles.

The film which has already secured numerous international accolades was shot in the picturesque landscapes of Dolpa.

'Shambhala' is said to be made spending approximately Rs.140 million.

Japan is rich, but many of its children are poor; a film documents the plight of single mothers

AP
Tokyo, Jan.23



The women work hard, sleeping only a few hours a night, as they juggle the demands of caring for their children and doing housework — all while suffering from poverty.

The award-winning independent documentary film "The Ones Left Behind," released last year, tells the story of such single mothers in Japan, weaving together interviews with the women and experts, and showing the other side of a culture whose ideal is for women to get married and become stay-at-home housewives and mothers.

"This is a topic that no one wants to really touch. In Japan, it's very taboo," Australian filmmaker Rionne McAvoy said Tuesday. "I think it's a very apt title because I feel that single mothers and their children have really been left behind in society."

One woman in the film says she works from 8:30 a.m. until 7:30 p.m., while earning less than 200,000 yen ($1,350) a month.

Tomiko Nakayama, another woman in the film, says: "I have to do everything on my own."

Despite being one of the world's richest nations, Japan has one of the highest rates of child poverty among OECD countries, with one in every seven children living in poverty. About half of single-parent households live below the poverty line.

Japanese society also tends to favor full-time male workers, and women often receive lower wages and fewer benefits, even when they are working full-time and overtime.

Another woman in the film is near tears as she describes how her child stopped asking her about take-your-parent-to-school days. She knew her mom was too busy and couldn't attend.

McAvoy's wife, Ayuri, who produced the film, was formerly a single mother. But both deny that's why Rionne McAvoy made the film. Initially, she wasn't interested in getting involved in his filmmaking.

What makes the story so "Japanese," according to Rionne McAvoy, is how the country's conformist culture makes many women accept their hardships, too ashamed to ask for help, "keeping their public face and private face separate," he told The Associated Press.

"The Ones Left Behind" was the Best Documentary Winner at the Miyakojima Charity International Film Festival last year and an official selection at the Yokohama International Film Festival.

Despite repeated promises by the Japanese government to provide monetary assistance to people with children, action has been slow, said Akihiko Kato, a professor at Meiji University who appears in the film.

That's partly why the birth rate is crashing in Japan from 1.2 million births in the year 2000 to below 700,000 today. Japan also lacks a system that can force fathers to pay child support, according to Kato.

In the past, grandparents, neighbors and other members of the extended family helped look after children. In the modern age of the nuclear family, the single-parent household is often on its own.

FIRST AUDITION OF THE NATIONAL DESIGNER RUNWAY CONCLUDES



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

The first audition for 'The National Designer Runway' concluded in Kathmandu recently. A total of 25 designers and 60 models participated in the event. Jury comprising senior journalist Saroj Ojha, entrepreneur Rubi Mahato, and past winner Biplav Raj Nagar Nahar judged the contestants.

The participants included aspiring designers, current fashion students, and enthusiasts, all competing for a coveted spot in the fashion limelight.

Saroj Ojha highlighted the presence of beauty pageant-winning models and seasoned fashion designers. The finale, scheduled for February 28 at Sukute Beach, promises a dazzling display of designer creations, with models strutting their stuff in carefully crafted outfits.

Swosti Dangal, Managing Director of Model Songs Nepal, emphasised that the winner would be decided based on both design excellence and runway performance. The organisers envision the National Designer Runway as a catalyst for promoting the fashion design sector and enhancing professionalism within the industry.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: Increased security can be built at this time. While you may have wanted to be less committed in the past in order to make room in case you find that one great love, home, roommate, or chosen family.

TAURUS: You're dipping your toe into the pool of spontaneity. While you're likely a creature of habit who doesn't enjoy frequently stepping outside of your comfort zone, you could be craving excitement and change.

GEMINI: You might be bursting with spiritual focus and excitement that you didn't have before. This is potentially coming from a place of spiritual peace and stability that encourages you to keep pursuing.

CANCER: New friends can nourish you to become your best (and happiest) self. You may have previously spent time around people who didn't understand you or your needs.

LEO: You might be making great leaps in your career. You could have been waiting a long time for a promotion, a raise, or just an acknowledgment of how much work you've put into your projects.

VIRGO: You're ready to show others who you really are and what you can do. This may mean that you're showing a peer a side of yourself that they couldn't have imagined, or that you've leveled up in a way.

LIBRA: You're going deeper. Perhaps you typically prefer to stay on the emotional surface in many instances, avoiding intense or extreme discussions, but sometimes it's good to feel those strong emotions.

SCORPIO: Someone who has entered your life might be showing you a better future. It's possible that they're championing a lifestyle that you've never thought to engage in before.

SAGITTARIUS: Exciting experiences with someone you never expected could be around every corner at the moment. People that you used to clash with could have a heart-to-heart with you.

CAPRICORN: The universe is letting loose -- and so can you. You may typically think of yourself as a serious or non-creative person or believe that your creativity isn't "good," but this might just be a story that you're telling yourself.

AQUARIUS: Your heart can improve the current circumstances for both you and others. You might not always be so keen to rely on your intuition or emotions, preferring to make use of your impressive logic.

PISCES: The words for what you really feel are easier to find right now. While you may have felt stifled as of late, you're being given more and more of a green light to say what's on your heart.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Karnali inflict 7th consecutive loss on Koshi

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

Karnali Province handed Koshi Province its seventh continuous loss in the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament at Mulpani International Cricket Ground on Day 11.

Put on to bat first, Koshi were bundled out in 34.3 overs with 151 runs on the scoreboard. Koshi reeled to 48/4 in 9th over as captain and opener Ankit Sutbedi (4 runs off 7 balls), Aaish Bhattarai (11 off 14), Sonu Ansari (8 off 19) and Suvan Gahataraj (0) returned to pavilion for cheap score.

It was Sujan Thapaliya who came to Koshi's rescue once again. Thapaliya, who scored a century against Nepal Police Club on Day 4, scored 73 runs off 73 deliveries after entering the crease at four. He hit four maximums and eight fours. Thapaliya lacked support from his partner on the crease as the wickets kept on falling. Before he departed at the 34th over leaving the team at 143/8, Firdosh Ansari (6 off 13), Samir Karki (6 off 16) and Avyash Timsina (9 off 34) had returned to the pavilion.

Saujan Ghimire, who came in at nine, was Koshi's second highest scorer with 12 off 22 balls. He fell as the last wicket as Karnali's bowlers bundled out Koshi at 151 runs in 34.3 overs.

Dinesh Adhikari took four wickets for Karnali while Prakash claimed three and Diwan Pun bagged two. Karnali only needed 28.3 overs to chase the target of 152 losing only four wickets. Wicketkeeper-batsman Arjun Gharti and Himanshu Shahi stayed not out and won the match for the team. Gharti reached his half-century and Shahi, who hit a six to settle the chase, scored 24 off 14.

Openers Bipin Shahi and Nischal Rawal scored 28 and 21 runs respectively. Hemant Rai took three wickets and Kamal Khatri took one for Koshi.

Meanwhile, Bagmati tasted its third loss of the tournament playing its seventh match against Gandaki at the TU International Cricket Ground on Tuesday.

Electing to bat first, Bagmati's openers Ashutosh Ghiraiya and Ishan Pandey were seen aggressive as the first wicket fell in the 21st over. Ghiraiya departed after scoring 44 off 69 leaving the team at 90/1.



PHOTO: BIKASH/TRN

After Ghiraiya's return, wicket started to tumble as Pandey departed in the 23rd scoring 43 off 62. Wicketkeeper-batsman Rabin Joshi and Pratik Shrestha departed for a duck while captain Rit Gautam could only add 13 runs in 20 balls.

Ashok Poudel, Bipin Acharya and Surya Tamang added 30, 38 and 15 runs respectively to help Bagmati reach 198. Kamal Pariyar bagged four wickets, Amrit Gurung and Bipin Khatri claimed two each for Gandaki.

Karan Pangeni was Gandaki's highest scorer in the chase where Bagmati's bowlers tried defending the low target. He scored 79 off 98.

Openers Sameer Kandel and Ishwar Chhetri, Mushkan Thapa and Kamal Pariyar scored 19, 36, 27 and 20 runs respectively as Gandaki chased the target with three balls to spare. Pratish GC took two wickets while Rijan Dhakal, Surya Tamang and Bipin Acharya bagged one each for Bagmati.

In a departmental derby between Nepal APF Club and Tribhuwan Army Club at Bhairahawa Cricket Ground, which was reduced to 36 overs each due to bad weather, Army emerged victorious by four wickets.

Electing to field first, Army was able to send 10 batsmen of APF back to the pavilion at 121 runs in the 33rd over. Sompal Kami pocketed three wickets and Avinash Karn dismissed two batters. APF captain Rohit Paudel, also Nepal's national team captain, was able to score a half century for the team. In the 103rd delivery he faced, Paudel was caught by Ahamad in the ball of Kami as the ninth wicket in 32.2 overs. He departed at 59 runs.

Only two other batsmen except Paudel – Sumit Maharjan (14 off 33) and Bhuvan Karki (16 off 20) – scored in double figures for APF.

Army chased the target in the 24th over losing six wickets. Captain Binod Bhandari and Bibek Yadav stayed not out at 34 runs and two runs respectively.

Openers Imran Sheikh and Santosh Karki added 16 and 11 runs respectively while Kushal Malla and Ahamad scored 19 and 18 runs respectively for Army.

Ramesh Kurmi took two wickets while Mousam Dhakal and captain Rohit bagged one each for APF.

Winners Army, Karnali and Gandaki are at the fourth, sixth and eighth positions in the league respectively. Losing sides Bagmati, APF and Koshi are in the second, seventh and tenth positions respectively.

Djokovic, Sabalenka make Australian Open semis

AFP
Melbourne, Jan. 23

Top seed Novak Djokovic battled past Taylor Fritz into an 11th Australian Open semi-final and a record-extending 48th at Grand Slams on Tuesday, but a rampant Aryna Sabalenka had a much easier ride.

The Serbian superstar came through a probing test on Rod Laver Arena against the 12th-seeded American 7-6 (7/3), 4-6, 6-2, 6-3 to keep his bid for an unprecedented 25th major crown on track. "Physically and emotionally very draining," he said after the three hour and 45 minute epic, adding that he "suffered a lot" in the first two sets.

"He was serving well, staying close to the line and kind of suffocating me from the back of the court," he said.

Djokovic has won all 10 previous semi-finals he has played at Melbourne Park, stretching back to his first title in 2008 and is on a 33-match unbeaten streak on the blue hardcourts.

In contrast to his long slog, fellow defending champion Sabalenka was off court in just 71 minutes, crushing ninth seed Barbora Krejcikova 6-2, 6-3 with minimum fuss.

She will face fourth seed Coco Gauff next in a replay of last year's US Open final that the American teenager won in three sets.

On current form, Gauff will be the underdog after taking more than three hours to down unseeded Ukrainian Marta Kostyuk 7-6 (8/6), 6-7 (3/7), 6-2 in a scrappy affair.

Great tennis

Sabalenka had won all seven of her previous Grand Slam quarter-finals, and wasted little time laying down the law against Krejcikova, the 2021 French Open champion. She broke three times in each set, with her booming groundstrokes unstoppable.

"I played really great tennis, I just hope I can keep playing this way," said the 25-year-old Sabalenka.

"I mean, it's all because of the atmosphere. I have the best support here."

Gauff admitted she was below par against Kostyuk, giving herself only a 'C' rating.

"Hopefully got the bad match out of the way and I can play even better," she said.

"Really proud of the fight I showed today," added the American, who had never progressed beyond the fourth round at Melbourne Park in four previous attempts.



SNIPPETS

Jhapa Gold Cup from March 2

Kathmandu (TRN): The sixth edition of Jhapa Gold Cup has been scheduled to be held in the month of March between ten teams. Organising a press conference at Birtamod on Tuesday, Jhapa District Football Association informed that the tournament will be held in Birtabazaar's Domalal Rajbanshi Stadium. Of the ten participating teams, seven will be Nepali and the remaining will be foreign teams. The organising team has also increased the prize money for the winners compared to the previous edition. The winner will now get Rs. 1.3 million and the runner-up will receive Rs. 700,000. The most valuable player of the tournament will also receive a motorcycle. Jhapa District Football Association informed that it plans to develop football in the district to a great extent.

Tajikistan reach Asian Cup knockouts

Doha (AFP): Debutants Tajikistan struck twice late on to beat Lebanon 2-1 and reach the Asian Cup knockout rounds on Monday but China's hopes are hanging by a thread after defeat to Qatar. It was a night of drama as Group A drew to a thrilling conclusion full of twists and turns. Hosts and holders Qatar were already through to the last 16 as group winners but China, Lebanon and Tajikistan were all fighting to progress with them. The top two from each of the six groups qualify automatically but going with them are the four best third-placed teams, adding an extra layer of intrigue. Qatar finished with a perfect nine points, with Tajikistan on four, China two and Lebanon one -- and on their way home.

E. Guinea crush I. Coast

Abidjan (AFP): Equatorial Guinea pulled off one of the most stunning results in Africa Cup of Nations history on Monday by thrashing hosts Ivory Coast 4-0 to win Group A and secure a last-16 place. They were joined in the knock-out phase by Nigeria, surprise Group B table-toppers Cape Verde and record seven-time champions Egypt. Nigeria beat Guinea-Bissau 1-0 to finish runners-up behind Equatorial Guinea and a dramatic 2-2 draw between Cape Verde and Egypt took both through. Ghana conceded two goals in added time to only draw 2-2 with Mozambique and, with only two points, may not be among the four best third-placed teams that also qualify and could be eliminated on Tuesday.

Three Star knocks host Sahara out

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 23

Three Star Club knocked out the host Sahara Club from the 23rd edition of the Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup in the opening match of the tournament at Pokhara Rangasala on Tuesday.

With a new leadership under Bikram Lama, a former player of Three Star Club, the players secured a win for the coach in his first match defeating Sahara Club 2-1.

Three Star scored the first goal in the fifth minute of the match from the foot of captain Yogesh Gurung. Gurung's header was blocked by Sahara's goalie Tekendra Thapa, but Thapa could not block the rebound hit by Gurung giving Three Star the lead.

However, Sahara Club bounced back with the equaliser in the 23rd minute. Aashish Gurung headed a free kick from Laxman Ruchal to the back of the net.

With the first half ending in a 1-1 draw, the winning goal came in the 59th minute as Anzal Maharjan scored from a free kick.

Three Star, a club that has won the Aaha! Rara Gold Cup five times already, will be looking for its sixth win as it enters the quarterfinals in a knockout-format.

Tribhuwan Army and Rising Star are facing each other in the second match of the tournament on Wednesday.

Martinez fires Inter to Italian Super Cup glory

AFP
Riyadh, Jan. 23

Lautaro Martinez shot Inter Milan to a third straight Italian Super Cup after netting in the final moments of Monday's 1-0 win over furious Napoli in Riyadh.

Argentina striker Martinez swept home Benjamin Pavard's low cross in the first minute of stoppage time at Al-Awwal Park, seeing off Napoli who played the final half-hour with 10 men after Giovanni Simeone was sent off for two bookable offences.

The 26-year-old's winner was his 21st goal in all competitions this season for Inter, who lost their Serie A lead to Juventus while in Saudi Arabia for the four-team tournament.

And he whipped his shirt off in celebration after drawing level with Christian Vieri at ninth place in Inter's all-time goalscoring charts, with 123 strikes since arriving in 2018.

"The emotion took over and I couldn't think," Martinez told Mediaset. "It was a unique moment, I scored my 100th goal in the Italian Cup Final and my 123rd goal in the Super Cup, allowing me to match a legend like Christian Vieri."

Martinez's goal gave Inter coach Simone Inzaghi a record-breaking fifth Super Cup win in his career after winning it for the third successive year. Inzaghi overtakes Fabio Capello and Marcello Lippi, two icons of Italian coaching, for Super Cup wins.



PHOTO: AP

Inter Milan's players celebrate after they won the Italian Super Cup final soccer match against Napoli at Al Awwal Park Stadium in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia.

> Martinez's goal gave Inter coach Simone Inzaghi a record-breaking fifth Super Cup win in his career after winning it for the third successive year.

Atletico into top four

Alvaro Morata's second-half winner secured Atletico Madrid a 1-0 victory at Granada on Monday, taking Diego Simeone's men into the La Liga top four.

The capital club took advantage of Athletic Bilbao's 1-0 loss at Valencia on Saturday to move above the Basque team into fourth on goals scored, with a game in hand.

Atletico are a distant 11 points adrift of surprise league leaders Girona. Morata broke the deadlock, though, in the 55th minute with a header, from a Griezmann cross, which survived a VAR check for offside.

Wasteful Wolves

Brighton were blunt in attack as the Seagulls were lucky to escape with a 0-0 draw at home to Wolves on Monday that did little for either side's ambitions of European football next season.

Wolves enjoyed the better of the chances despite enjoying just 28 percent possession but Pedro Neto and Matheus Cunha failed to find the finish.

A share of the spoils leaves seventh-placed Brighton still three points ahead of their opponents, who remain in 11th.

Brighton kept their first clean sheet in the Premier League since May on their last outing against West Ham, that also ended in a 0-0 stalemate.

WEATHER

Wednesday

Sunrise at 6:54 am, Sunset at 5:38 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Wednesday)

Partly to generally cloudy in the hilly regions of the country and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at a few places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and at one or two places of high hilly and mountainous regions of rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 16 - 18°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Tuesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	15.5	2.9	0.0
Dipayal	22.6	3.5	0.0
Dhangadi	15.6	2.7	0.0
Birendranagar	22.0	4.4	0.0
Nepalgunj	18.3	4.3	0.0
Jumla	13.2	-2.5	0.0
Ghorahi	21.1	4.4	0.0
Pokhara	19.3	6.6	0.0
Bhairahawa	17.7	4.5	0.0
Simara	19.5	4.0	0.0
Kathmandu	17.8	3.4	0.0
Okhaldhunga	16.3	5.8	0.0
Taplejung	14.5	3.6	0.0
Dhankuta	20.2	3.6	0.0
Biratnagar	22.5	7.5	0.0
Jomsom	7.1	-2.0	0.0*
Dharan	23.3	9.5	0.0*
Lumle	14.2	3.8	0.0*
Janakpur	22.4	7.5	0.0*
Jiri	13.0	-0.6	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES
January 24, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.75	Rs. 133.35
Euro	1	Rs. 144.21	Rs. 144.86
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.65	Rs. 169.41
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 152.71	Rs. 153.40
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.32	Rs. 87.71
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.48	Rs. 98.92
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.02	Rs. 99.47
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.97	Rs. 9.01
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.51	Rs. 18.60
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.40	Rs. 35.56
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.41	Rs. 36.58
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.71	Rs. 3.73
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.14	Rs. 36.31
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.08	Rs. 28.21
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.92	Rs. 9.96
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.70	Rs. 12.75
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.34	Rs. 19.42
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.97	Rs. 17.05
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.27	Rs. 433.22
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.17	Rs. 353.76

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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